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DRIVERS OF Change

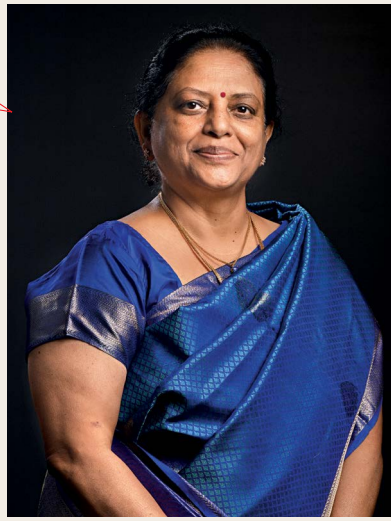
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into the companies whose boards she served on. "We wanted to bring women to the top. We ensured that women were given a chance at leadership positions," she said. R.M. Vishakha, CEO of IndiaFirst Life Insurance, confessed that she "had been passed over many times".

While corporate India may be creating women-friendly workplaces, it's rural India that needs real change. Tejdeep Kaur Menon recalled how she was admonished by a senior for arresting a criminal-on-the-run. Anukriti Sharma, the first female top cop in Uttar Pradesh's Sambal district, ensures gender equality in policing duties and has created a '*bike wali didi*' force of women patrollers. Special forces trainer Dr Seema Rao, another woman in a male-dominated field, didn't let a near-fatal injury come in the way of pursuing her career. "I didn't want my reflection in the mirror to tell me—you were scared," she says.

Compassion and kindness, said all the winners, were the biggest qualities that differentiated women from men. Mirza, an actor-producer, eco-investor and climate activist, works purposefully to protect the environment despite receiving hate mails. "The nurturer in me helps in making informed choices to make our world a better place for our children," she said. Cellist Saskia Rao-de Haas set the tone for the evening by playing a piece in praise of goddess Durga. As a foreigner in the field of Indian classical music, she is seeking to make music accessible to children and use it for educational purposes too. A key to success, she said, lay in having the support of loved ones that encourage women to soar higher. ■

TESSY THOMAS
Director-General, DRDO
The 'missile woman of India' is a role model for women in the field of science & technology





KRITI BHARTI
Child Rights Activist
Fighting patriarchy, she has saved children and women from abuse and exploitation

MITTAL PATEL
Social Activist
Works for the upliftment of nomadic and denotified tribes of India





SONIA JABBAR
Wildlife Conservationist
Runs an elephant-friendly tea estate, encourages leadership in women

SASKIA RAO-DE HAAS
Cello Maestro
She is making Indian classical music accessible to children

